



Job Sharing: A Viable Work Alternative for the New Millennium

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Executive Summary

Job sharing typically is defined as two workers sharing the duties of one full-time position. While there are many benefits to this work option, disadvantages also exist and the individuals involved must be capable of working as efficiently as one employee. Radical changes have occurred in the work force in recent years. Companies have been reexamining this alternative work arrangement during a time of tremendous diversity and change in order to keep up with the challenges and to more effectively utilize the work force. This paper explores the job sharing concept, discusses the results of a survey examining job sharing perceptions among employees and managers, and outlines why it is a viable alternative in the workplace today.

Introduction

In 1978 the Federal Employees Part-Time Career Employment Act focused on increasing the utilization of employees who desired to work less than a traditional 40-hour work week (Catalyst, 1989). This commitment was strengthened in 1994 when President Clinton sent a memorandum to executive departments and agencies encouraging the establishment and support of flexible family-friendly work arrangements. These would include various part-time and job-sharing work schedules. "Virtual staffing" is a term that has been used to define the various forms of flexible scheduling and "virtual staffers" are the employees who hold these flexible jobs (Davey, 1998). Job sharing is one form of virtual staffing developed in the 1960's, which allowed two people to fulfill the responsibilities of one full-time position. Typically the two individuals involved work opposite shifts or opposite days, depending on the type of flexibility desired. In the 1960's and 1970's job sharing was typically utilized in clerical-level jobs in the public and private sector. However, as previously mentioned, in 1978 the government passed legislation authorizing job sharing for federal employees in professional positions and this opened the door for increased implementation of job sharing.

Whether they wanted to or not, companies have had to implement flexible work arrangements in order to satisfy the needs of employees and retain quality employees, particularly when workers were in short supply during the 1990s. Employers simply could not afford to *not* take proactive steps to hire and retain workers. Job sharing came into popularity when the challenge of having dual-income households conflicted with family obligations. It has been estimated by the Bureau of Labor Statistics that the percentage of the work force made up by females will be approximately 48 percent by 2008 and that 27 percent of these women will be